

Publish more guidance

For example, we could create a guide to help you find, access, and understand archived pages in the web archive.

It could describe what an archived web page is, the scope of the web archive, how to search, and what gaps in the archive might mean.

Researchers would then explore the archive themselves.

[Home](#) > [Help with your research](#) > [Research guides](#) > Census records

How to look for records of...

Census records

How can I view the records covered in this guide?

☒ [View Online](#) ☒ [Order copies](#) ☒ [Visit us in Kew](#) ☒ [Pay for research](#)

How many are online?

☐ None ☐ Some ☒ All

1. Why use this guide?

This guide explains how to access the historical censuses from 1841 to 1921 and provides information on using the census returns of:

- England
- Wales
- the Channel Islands
- the Isle of Man
- vessels in English and Welsh ports and inland waterways from 1861 onwards
- the British Army overseas (1911 and 1921 only)
- RAF bases overseas (1921 only)

Contents

[1. Why use this guide?](#)

[2. What is the census and why was it compiled?](#)

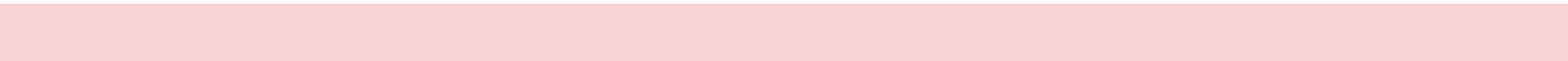
[3. How the census was taken and on what dates](#)

[4. Where to access and how to search the censuses](#)

[5. People in the census](#)

[6. Places in the census](#)

Publish more guidance



If we created more guidance, users would consult this to help them know where to look in the web archive.

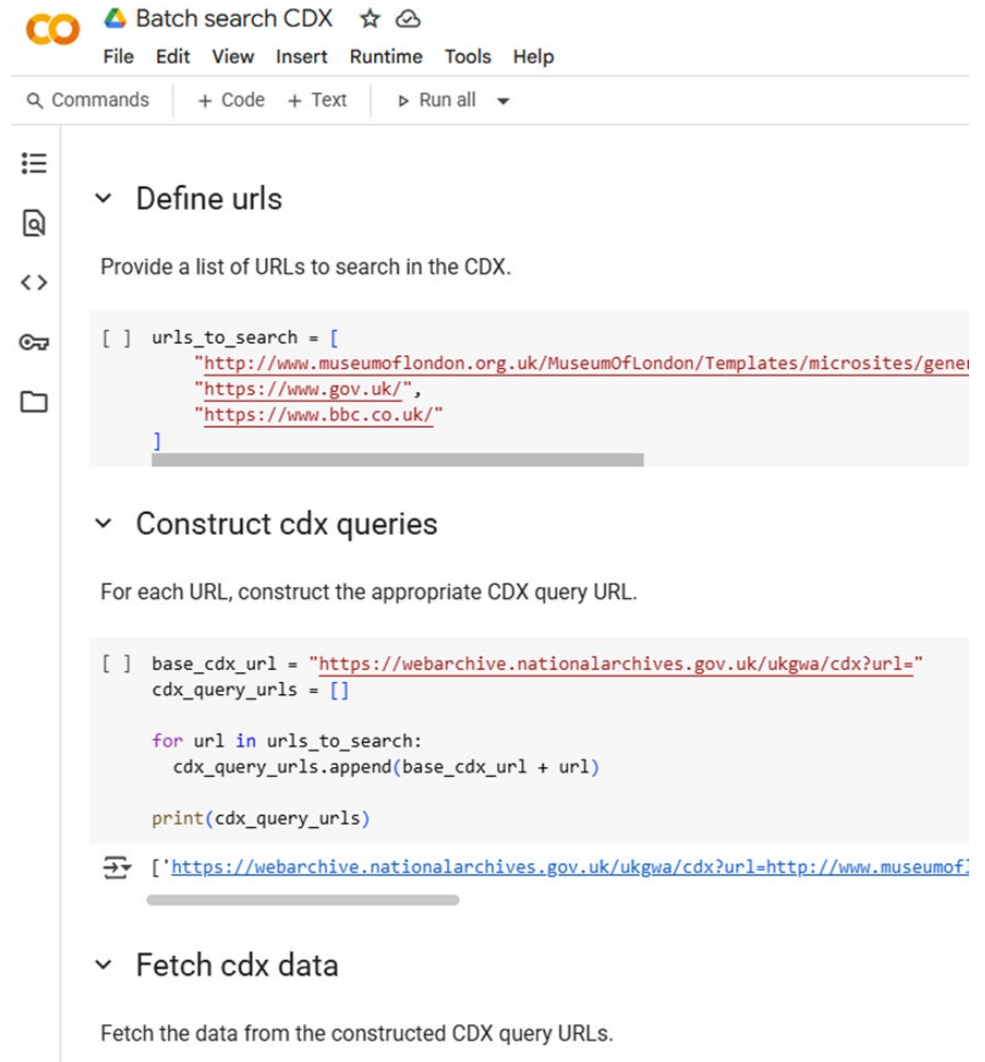


Publish user-friendly notebooks

The UKGWA publish a series of simple python notebooks with tutorials.

Examples of types of information we could share include:

- How to access and export the CDX
- What the CDX results mean
- N-gram code
- Search results overview



The screenshot shows a Jupyter Notebook interface with the title 'Batch search CDX'. The notebook contains two sections:

- Define urls**: A section with the instruction 'Provide a list of URLs to search in the CDX.' followed by a code cell containing a list of URLs to search:

```
[ ] urls_to_search = [
    "http://www.museumoflondon.org.uk/MuseumOfLondon/Templates/microsites/gene",
    "https://www.gov.uk/",
    "https://www.bbc.co.uk/"
]
```
- Construct cdx queries**: A section with the instruction 'For each URL, construct the appropriate CDX query URL.' followed by a code cell containing Python code to construct CDX queries:

```
[ ] base_cdx_url = "https://webarchive.nationalarchives.gov.uk/ukgwa/cdx?url="
cdx_query_urls = []

for url in urls_to_search:
    cdx_query_urls.append(base_cdx_url + url)

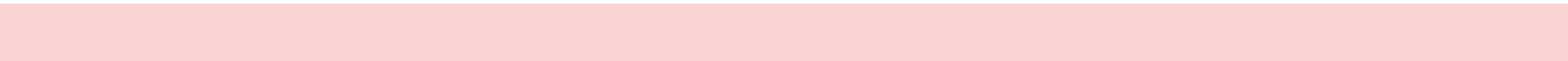
print(cdx_query_urls)
```

 Below the code cell, the output is shown:

```
['https://webarchive.nationalarchives.gov.uk/ukgwa/cdx?url=http://www.museumofl
```



Publish user-friendly notebooks



If we publish user-friendly notebooks, researchers would use these to extract some of their own data, analyse results, or spring-board into their own computational work with our public data.



Curated special collections

Specific areas of the web archive are highlighted on the archive homepage, allowing users to more easily discover and navigate through highlighted collections.

Some examples could be:

- London 2012 Olympic and Paralympic Games
- Coronavirus Pandemic
- Brexit
- 2008 Financial Crisis

Special Collections - UK Government Web Archive

← → ↺ <https://webarchive.nationalarchives.gov.uk/special-collections/>

UK Government Web Archive - Explore our special collections

[Placeholder text for the main heading area]



[Early government web](#)
1996 - 2000 12 sites
[Placeholder text]



[2008 Financial Crisis](#)
2008 - 2010 7 sites
[Placeholder text]



[2012 Olympic and Paralympic games](#)
1996 - 2000 15 sites
[Placeholder text]



[Commemorations](#)
2014 - 2025 12 sites
[Placeholder text]

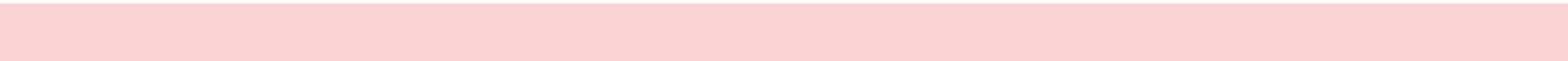


[Brexit](#)
2016 - 2020 23 sites
[Placeholder text]



[Coronavirus \(COVID-19\)](#)
2020 - 2023 30 sites
[Placeholder text]

Curated special collections



If we hosted curated special collections, researchers would use these to explore specific, highlighted areas of the UK Government Web Archive collection.



Archivists share data from internal database

Internally, we are using AWS technology to query content in the archive and their accompanying metadata at scale.

In future, we could share this data with researchers upon request. You would need to speak with an archivist to ascertain exactly what data you wanted, and they would then create a dataset for you to work with.



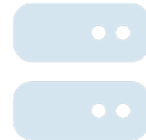
You come to us with a specific project in mind



We help you determine what data from the archive would be both useful and accessible



Our team extract the data and check there are no Takedown conflicts before sharing



You can work with the data, and we have a very good idea of who you are and what data you have!



Archivists share data from internal database

If archivists were able to share data from our internal databases, researchers would be able to analyse specific datasets that archivists work with in their day to day job.



Publication of derived datasets

Datasets that do not reveal specific information from the web archive are a way for us to let you work with data at scale, without putting ourselves at risk of publishing data that could later be removed through a Takedown request.

We could share derived datasets that allow researchers to get a shape of our collection without disclosing large amounts of sensitive information such as names.

Token counts:

that: 8871
his: 8283
was: 7355
he: 7044
with: 6865
my: 5149
you: 5063
had: 5016
her: 4413
Mr.: 4346

Topic models:

<topic id="0">
<word weight="1146">feet</word>
<word weight="1018">found</word>
<word weight="823">form</word>
<word weight="697">strata</word>
<word weight="683">beds</word>
<word weight="632">part</word>
<word weight="626">colour</word>
<word weight="603">rocks</word>
<word weight="569">red</word>
<word weight="562">substance</word>
</topic>

Archived content types over time:

1	mime	year_month	item_count	total_length	Year	Avg_siz	mime_top-level
65964	image/jpeg	202404	6336160	5.39E+11	2024	85011.74	image
65965	image/png	202404	1182762	1.10E+11	2024	92961.22	image
65966	image/mpo	202404	2	277460	2024	138730	image
65967	image/bmp	202404	81	14081514	2024	173845.9	image
65968	image/pipeg	202404	14	4455971	2024	318283.6	image
65969	image/pjpeg	202404	31	10861475	2024	350370.2	image
65970	image/tiff	202404	220	2137975922	2024	9718072	image
65971	image/ico	202405	17	24220	2024	1424.706	image
65972	image/x-icon	202405	4085	12237044	2024	2995.604	image
65973	image/vnd.m	202405	1660	5515740	2024	3322.735	image
65974	image/gif	202405	138410	1032946736	2024	7462.949	image
65975	image/svg+xr	202405	459548	3455879091	2024	7520.17	image
65976	Image/x-png	202405	4	35764	2024	8941	Image
65977	image/webp	202405	1392767	13079597609	2024	9391.088	image
65978	image/x.fb.ke	202405	45	857970	2024	19066	image
65979	Image/Png	202405	2	41022	2024	20511	Image
65980	image/pjpeg	202405	3	65948	2024	21982.67	image
65981	image/avif	202405	5897	192116774	2024	32578.73	image
65982	image/jpeg	202405	2054255	1.04E+11	2024	50570.64	image
65983	Image/ipeg	202405	10	540295	2024	54029.5	Image



Publication of derived datasets

If we published derived datasets, users would then do their own data-lead research with select snippets of the collection that we know are safe to release and use.



Consultation service

There is work to be done internally to prepare ourselves to respond more readily to research inquiries. We could then provide more bespoke datasets in response to specific inquiries, for example providing sensitive data upon arrangement.

Researchers would sign a data agreement in order to access their bespoke dataset. This way, we can keep track of who is accessing sensitive data and where.



You come to us with a specific project in mind



We help you determine what data from the archive you require, with scope to look beyond metadata and examine websites themselves



We trial a small-scale extraction of your data so that we can give you an estimate costing



You agree with us on the type of data, the cost, and sign a data agreement



We deliver your data!



Consultation service

If we were able to consult individual researchers and provide bespoke datasets, researchers would work with more sensitive data that directly relates to their own research questions.



Search faceting on the webpage

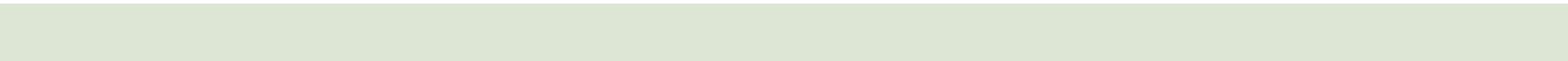
An 'advanced search' option when searching our catalogue to allow greater fidelity.

For example:

- Filter by file type (e.g. image search)
- Filter by collection
- Filter by capture date
- Sort
- Entity recognition grouping options

The screenshot displays the 'Advanced Search - UK Government Web Archive' page. At the top, the browser address bar shows the URL <https://webarchive.nationalarchives.gov.uk/search/advanced/>. Below the header, the title 'UK Government Web Archive - Advanced Search' is followed by a large, faint watermark text. A search bar prompts the user to 'search by keyword(s), Named Entity, or URL'. The 'Filter by...' section contains three panels: 'Content type' with checkboxes for text/HTML, image/JPEG, application/pdf, image/Png, text/csv, text/plain, and image/GIF; 'Collection' with checkboxes for Early government web, Elections, 2008 Financial Crisis, Olympic and Paralympic Games, Commemorations, Brexit, and Coronavirus Pandemic; and 'Capture date' with date pickers for 'from' (01/05/1997) and 'to' (07/06/2001). The 'Sort by...' panel offers options: Capture date (ascending), Capture date (descending), Term frequency, and Surt. The 'Group by...' panel lists Organisation, Geographical location, Organisation, Domain, and Capture year. Each panel includes an information icon (i) and a dropdown arrow.

Search faceting on the webpage



If we had an advanced search option on our website, users would be able to filter their searches and get more relevant results during the research journey.



Enhanced search exports

Currently you can export the first 10,000 results from search and you will get a limited amount of information about each page.

Enhanced search exports would give you more than the first 10,000 rows of results, and include text extracts from each page. This text would be the same as the text that you see besides your search results.

Current export

Timestamp	URL	Title
17.04.2010	www.lovechips.co.uk	Cheggar's Chip Tune



Enhanced search export

Timestamp	URL	Title	Text extract
17.04.2010	www.lovechips.co.uk	Cheggar's Chip Tune	Chip Tune Archive Back in 2009, Cheggers wrote his very own chip tune and even made his own music video!

More
results
exported



Enhanced search exports

If enhanced search exports were enabled, users would be able to analyse more information related to a greater number of websites at a time.



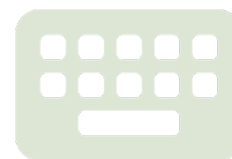
Exhibition search

Specific areas of the collection are indexed in greater detail. This would offer a curated approach to the search experience, as material highlighted by subject specialists would be easier to search.

The result is a more focused search experience – like browsing through an assembled exhibition – where users are guided towards resources and thematic groupings that reflect aspects of the collection deemed as important or in high demand.



You select an area of the collection you would like to search within

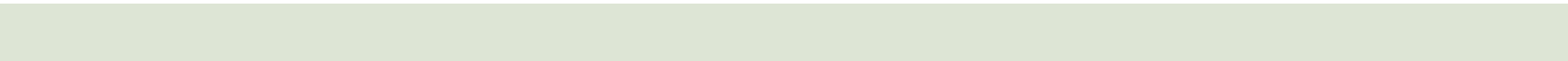


You enter your own search terms into the interface as normal



Websites within the collection you have searched are easier to find

Exhibition search



If we enabled exhibition search, users would get a better search experience in specific areas of the collection.



Bespoke research infrastructure

A bespoke research infrastructure for users to search and interact with data within a secure environment where large amounts of data cannot be exported, similar to a Hathi Trust data capsule.

This is the most computationally intense proposition, but is it worth it?

Advanced Search - UK Government Web Archive

← → ↺

https://webarchive.nationalarchives.gov.uk/research-platform/

UK Government Web Archive Research Platform

DataHelpAccount

a.researcher@uni.ac.ukLogout

Manage datasets

New datasetExisting datasets

Generate new dataset by...

Q

▼

☐ WARC filename(s)☐ CDX query☐ Keyword search☐ Date range☐ Named entities☐ Domain

Limit dataset by...

Q

▼

☐ Size☐ Number of items☐ Number of WARC files☐ Estimated generation time☐ Content type

☒ Preview

Build query

Explore

Q Select dataset ▼

Overview

Metadata

Text

Topics

Change

Network

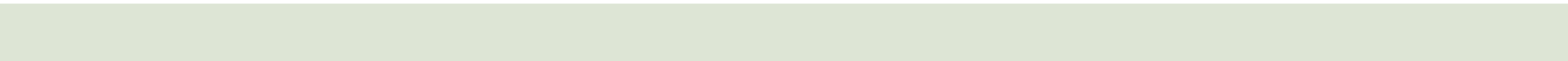
Entities

Export to secure environment

Q Select dataset or derived data ▼

Export

Bespoke research infrastructure



If we created a bespoke research infrastructure, users would search and interact with data within a secure environment.

